



JAMMU | Making the Right Noises

In contrast to the media hyperbole about his becoming the youngest chief minister of Jammu & Kashmir, Omar Abdullah kept his swearing-in on January 5 at Jammu a remarkably low-key event. Omar let the symbolism speak for his agenda of making good governance the leitmotif of his regime. The presence of UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi at the coronation of the third generation scion of the Abdullah dynasty was a clear pointer to a rapid cementing of ties between the Congress and the National Conference, almost two decades after they had fallen foul of each other. Not surprisingly, the Congress portrayed itself as a magnanimous ally, agreeing to Omar's suggestion of not having rotational chief minister-ship. That arrangement had created much bad blood between the Congress and the People's Democratic Party in the previous coalition government. The 10-member Cabinet has five ministers from the Congress; its leader Tara Chand is likely to be deputy chief minister. Omar has made all the right noises on his challenges, particularly those around striking a delicate balance between the Hindu-dominated Jammu and the Muslim-majority Valley as the two regions are still in the shadows of religious and regional polarisation. Omar, now in the hottest seat of state power, will need all the tactical diplomacy he can muster. *by Ramesh Vinayak*

**OMAR
ABDULLAH
HAS TOUGH
CHALLENGES
AHEAD**

45

battalions
(45,000
soldiers) of
the Border
Security
Force are
deployed
along the
Indo-Pak
border from
J&K to
Gujarat.